



Story 1 — *The Last Shift at Maple Ridge Arena*

Hockey Story

Maple Ridge Arena had always smelled like cold air, sharpened steel, and childhood dreams. For seventeen-year-old Liam Carver, it was the place where he learned to skate, learned to lose, and learned to get back up again.

Tonight was different. The arena lights hummed overhead as the crowd gathered for the final game of the season — the Maple Ridge Timberwolves versus their long-time rivals, the North River Falcons. Liam tightened his helmet, feeling the familiar pressure settle around his temples.

Coach Ramirez clapped him on the shoulder. “Last shift of the season, kid. Make it count.”

The puck dropped. The Falcons came out fast, slicing across the ice with practiced precision. Liam chased the play, his skates carving deep lines as he pushed harder than he ever had. The Timberwolves were down by one with thirty seconds left.

Then it happened — a turnover at center ice. Liam intercepted the puck, heart pounding. He sprinted toward the net, defenders closing in. He faked left, cut right, and snapped a wrist shot that echoed through the arena like a crack of thunder.

The red goal light flashed. The crowd erupted.

Liam didn’t hear the cheers. He only felt the rush — the moment where effort, fear, and hope collided into something unforgettable.

The Timberwolves didn’t win the championship that night. But Liam’s goal tied the game and sent it into overtime, giving Maple Ridge one last memory before the arena closed for renovations.

And for Liam, it was the night he realized he wasn’t just playing hockey.

He was becoming who he wanted to be.